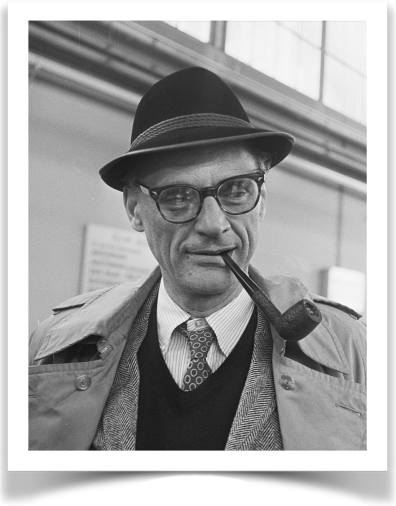
The Death of a Salesman

Arthur Miller

This is an excerpt from the play *The Death of a Salesman* by Arthur Miller.

Arthur Miller: An Introduction



Arthur Miller (1915–2005) occupies a prominent place in twentieth-century American drama. Born in New York City, he grew up in a prosperous family engaged in the textile manufacturing business. The economic collapse of the Great Depression in the 1930s brought financial ruin to his family, an experience that profoundly shaped his understanding of American society and later influenced his dramatic works.

Before establishing himself as a playwright, Miller worked in several occupations and studied at the University of Michigan, where he began writing plays. His early success came with *All My Sons* (1947), a drama that explored moral responsibility and the consequences of individual actions. His international reputation was secured with *Death of a Salesman* (1949), which won the Pulitzer Prize and the Tony Award. Other notable works include *The Crucible* (1953), *A View from the Bridge* (1955), *After the Fall* (1964), and *The Price* (1968).

Miller's plays are characterized by their exploration of family relationships, social pressures, personal responsibility, and the conflict between individual aspirations and social realities. Unlike traditional tragedy, which often centres on kings and noble figures, Miller believed that ordinary people could also be tragic heroes. His protagonists are frequently common individuals struggling to preserve their dignity and identity in a society that measures success through wealth, status, and achievement.

As a dramatist, Miller combined psychological insight with social criticism. His works examine the tensions between private desires and public expectations, revealing how social values can shape individual lives. Deeply concerned with questions of justice, morality, and human responsibility, he used theatre as a means of exploring the ethical dilemmas faced by modern individuals.

Miller's influence extends far beyond American literature. His plays continue to be read, studied, and performed across the world because they address universal concerns such as ambition, failure, guilt, family conflict, and the search for meaning. Through his powerful dramatic vision, Arthur Miller transformed modern theatre and remains one of the most significant playwrights of the modern age.

Introduction to the Play

Published and first performed in 1949, *Death of a Salesman* is widely regarded as Arthur Miller's masterpiece and one of the most important plays in modern American drama. The play examines the life of Willy Loman, an ageing travelling salesman whose faith in the promise of success gradually collapses under the pressure of economic failure and personal disappointment.

The origins of the play can be traced to a short story Miller wrote as a teenager about an unsuccessful salesman. The character of Willy Loman was also partly inspired by Miller's uncle, Manny Newman, a travelling salesman whose unwavering optimism persisted despite repeated setbacks. These influences enabled Miller to create a character who embodies both the aspirations and the frustrations of ordinary Americans.

The play centres on the Loman family: Willy, his wife Linda, and their sons Biff and Happy. Through their relationships, Miller explores themes such as the American Dream, success and failure, family conflict, illusion and reality, and the search for personal identity. The play is notable for its innovative dramatic structure, which blends present action with memories, dreams, and hallucinations. Past and present coexist on the stage, allowing the audience to experience the inner workings of Willy's mind.

By combining social criticism with psychological depth, *Death of a Salesman* presents the tragedy of an ordinary individual whose dreams are shaped by the values of the society in which he lives.

Summary of the Play

The action of *Death of a Salesman* takes place during the final twenty-four hours of Willy Loman's life. Willy is a sixty-three-year-old salesman who has devoted his life to the belief that personal charm and popularity are the keys to success. However, advancing age and declining professional prospects have left him exhausted, financially insecure, and increasingly unable to cope with reality.

The play begins when Willy returns home from a failed business trip. As he struggles with disappointment and confusion, his thoughts repeatedly drift into memories of the past. These memories reveal his high expectations for his sons, particularly Biff, who had been a successful high-school athlete with great promise. Willy had imagined a future in which Biff would achieve the success that he himself had failed to attain.

The relationship between father and son lies at the heart of the drama. Biff's admiration for Willy was shattered when he discovered his father's extramarital affair. Since then, Biff has been unable to accept the values and ambitions that Willy represents. While Willy continues to cling to dreams of success, Biff gradually comes to recognize the emptiness of those dreams.

As the play progresses, Willy loses his job and becomes increasingly isolated. Unable to reconcile his expectations with reality, he convinces himself that his life insurance money will provide Biff with the opportunity to succeed. Believing that his death will be worth more than his life, Willy commits suicide in a final attempt to secure his family's future.

The play concludes with Willy's funeral. Biff recognizes the destructive nature of his father's illusions, while Linda mourns the loss of a man who spent his life pursuing a dream that remained forever out of reach.

Historical and Social Context

Death of a Salesman emerged in post-war America, a period marked by economic expansion and growing faith in material prosperity. At the centre of the play is the idea of the American Dream—the belief that hard work, determination, and personal initiative will lead to success and social advancement. Miller examines both the appeal and the limitations of this ideal.

Although the play was written after the Great Depression, its influence is evident throughout the work. The economic hardships experienced during the 1930s exposed the fragility of dreams based solely on financial success. Willy Loman represents a generation that continued to believe in the promises of prosperity even when reality offered little support for such optimism.

The play also reflects the rapid urbanization and modernization of American society. Willy's house, once surrounded by open space and nature, is now enclosed by apartment buildings. This physical transformation symbolizes the loss of personal freedom, security, and connection with nature. At the same time, increasing competition and economic pressures create a sense of isolation and insecurity.

Miller uses Willy's story to critique a society that measures human worth in terms of material achievement. The play questions whether success should be defined by wealth, popularity, and professional status or by personal integrity, meaningful relationships, and self-understanding. In this way, *Death of a Salesman* functions both as a family tragedy and as a social commentary on modern capitalist society.

More than seventy years after its first performance, the play remains relevant because it addresses universal concerns about ambition, identity, family relationships, and the gap between dreams and reality. Its enduring appeal lies in its ability to connect personal tragedy with broader social issues, making it one of the most significant works of modern drama.

The part prescribed for study occurs in the first part of Act 1 where an exhausted Willy talks to his wife Linda. The part projects Willy Loman's disoriented nature, his hopes and hopelessness and his relationship with his wife Linda.

Text

The action takes place in Willy Loman's house and yard and in various places he visits in the New York and Boston of today.

Act 1 - Part 1 (Conversation between Willy and Linda)

A melody is heard, played upon a flute. It is small and fine, tell-in of grass and trees and the horizon.

The curtain rises.

Before us is the Salesman's house. We are aware of towering, angular shapes behind it, surrounding it on all sides. Only the blue light of the sky falls upon the house and forestage; the surrounding area shows an angry glow of orange. As more light appears, we see a solid vault of apartment houses around the small, fragile-seeming home. An air of the dream dings to the place, a dream rising out of reality. The kitchen at centre seems actual enough, for there is a kitchen table with three chairs, and a refrigerator. But no other fixtures are seen. At the back of the kitchen there is a draped entrance, which leads to the living room. To the right of the kitchen, on a level raised two feet, is a bedroom furnished only with a brass bedstead and a straight chair. On a shelf over the bed a silver athletic trophy stands. A window opens onto the apartment house at the side.

Behind the kitchen, on a level raised six and a half feet, is the boys' bedroom, at present barely visible. Two beds are dimly seen, and at the back of the room a dormer

window. (This bedroom is above the unseen living room.) At the left a stairway curves up to it from the kitchen.

The entire setting is wholly or, in some places, partially transparent. The roof-line of the house is one-dimensional; under and over it we see the apartment buildings. Before the house lies an apron, curving beyond the forestage into the orchestra. This for. ward area serves as the backyard as well as the locale of all Willy's imaginings and of his city scenes. Whenever the action is in the present the actors observe the imaginary wall-lines, entering the house only through its door at the left. But in the scenes of the past these boundaries are broken, and characters enter or leave a room by stepping through a wall onto the forestage.

From the right, Willy Loman, the Salesman, enters, carrying two large sample cases. The flute plays on. He hears but is not aware of it. He is past sixty years of age, dressed quietly. Even as he crosses the stage to the doorway of the house, his exhaustion is apparent. He unlocks the door, comes into the kitchen, and thankfully lets his burden down, feeling the soreness of his palms. A word-sigh escapes his lips it might be »Oh, boy, oh, boy.<< He closes the door, then carries his cases out into the living room, through the draped kitchen doorway.

Linda, his wife, has stirred in her bed at the right. She gets out and puts on a robe, listening. Most often jovial, she has developed an iron repression of her exceptions to Willy's behaviour — she more than loves him, she admires him, as though his mercurial nature, his temper, his massive dreams and little cruelties, served her only as sharp reminders of the turbulent longings within him, longings which she shares but lacks the temperament to utter and follow to their end.

LINDA (hearing Willy outside the bedroom, calls with some trepidation): Willy!

WILLY: It's all right. I came back.

LINDA: Why? What happened? (Slight pause.) Did something happen, Willy?

WILLY: No, nothing happened.

LINDA: You didn't smash the car, did you?

WILLY (with casual irritation): I said nothing happened. Didn't you hear me?

LINDA: Don't you feel well?

WILLY: I'm tired to the death. (The flute has faded away. He sits on the bed beside her, a little numb.) I couldn't make it. I just couldn't make it, Linda.

LINDA (very carefully, delicately): Where were you all day? You look terrible.

WILLY: I got as far as a little above Yonkers. I stopped for a cup of coffee. Maybe it was the coffee.

LINDA: What?

WILLY (after a pause): I suddenly couldn't drive any more. The car kept going off onto the shoulder, know?

LINDA (helpfully): Oh. Maybe it was the steering again. I don't think Angelo knows the Studebaker.

WILLY: No, it's me, it's me. Suddenly I realize I'm going' sixty miles an hour and I don't remember the last five minutes. I'm I can't seem to keep my mind to it.

LINDA: Maybe it's your glasses. You never went for your new glasses.

WILLY: No, I see everything. I came back ten miles an hour. It took me nearly four hours from Yonkers.

LINDA (resigned): Well, you'll just have to take a rest, Willy, you can't continue this way.

WILLY: I just got back from Florida.

LINDA: But you didn't rest your mind. Your mind is overactive, and the mind is what counts, dear.

WILLY: I'll start out in the morning. Maybe I'll feel better in the morning. (She is taking off his shoes.) These goddamn arch supports are killing me.

LINDA: Take an aspirin. Should I get you an aspirin? It'll soothe you.

WILLY (with wonder): I was driving along, you understand? And I was fine. I was even observing the scenery. You can imagine, me looking at scenery, on the road every week of my life. But it's so beautiful up there, Linda, the trees are so thick, and the sun is warm. I opened the windshield and just let the warm air bathe over me. And then all of a sudden I'm goin' off the road! I'm tellin'ya, I absolutely forgot I was driving. If I'd've gone the other way over the white line I might've killed somebody. So I went on again and five minutes later I'm dreamin' again, and I nearly... (He presses two fingers against his eyes.) I have such thoughts, I have such strange thoughts.

LINDA: Willy, dear. Talk to them again. There's no reason why you can't work in New York.

WILLY: They don't need me in New York. I'm the New England man. I'm vital in New England.

LINDA: But you're sixty years old. They can't expect you to keep travelling every week.

WILLY: I'll have to send a wire to Portland. I'm supposed to see Brown and Morrison tomorrow morning at ten o'clock to show the line. Goddammit, I could sell them! (He starts putting on his jacket.)

LINDA (taking the jacket from him): Why don't you go down to the place tomorrow and tell Howard you've simply got to work in New York? You're too accommodating, dear.Y

WILLY: If old man Wagner was alive I'd be in charge of New York now! That man was a prince, he was a masterful man. But that boy of his, that Howard, he don't appreciate. When I went north the first time, the Wagner Company didn't know where New England was!

LINDA: Why don't you tell those things to Howard, dear?

WILLY (encouraged): I will, I definitely will. Is there any cheese?

LINDA: I'll make you a sandwich.

WILLY: No, go to sleep. I'll take some milk. I'll be up right away.

The boys in?

LINDA: They're sleeping. Happy took Biff on a date tonight.

WILLY (interested): That so?

LINDA: It was so nice to see them shaving together, one behind the other, in the bathroom. And going out together. You notice? The whole house smells of shaving lotion.

WILLY: Figure it out. Work a lifetime to pay off a house. You finally own it, and there's nobody to live in it.

LINDA: Well, dear, life is a casting off. It's always that way.

WILLY: No, no, some people- some people accomplish something. Did Biff say anything after I went this morning?

LINDA: You shouldn't have criticized him, Willy, especially after he just got off the train. You mustn't lose your temper with him.

WILLY: When the hell did I lose my temper? I simply asked him if he was making any money. Is that a criticism?

LINDA: But, dear, how could he make any money?

WILLY (worried and angered): There's such an undercurrent in him. He became a moody man. Did he apologize when I left this morning?

LINDA: He was crestfallen, Willy. You know how he admires you. I think if he finds himself, then you'll both be happier and not fight any more.

WILLY: How can he find himself on a farm? Is that a life? A farm-hand? In the beginning, when he was young, I thought, well, a young man, it's good for him to tramp around, take a lot of different jobs. But it's more than ten years now and he has yet to make thirty-five dollars a week!

LINDA: He's finding himself, Willy.tidy

WILLY: Not finding yourself at the age of thirty-four is a disgrace!

LINDA: Shh!

WILLY: The trouble is he's lazy, goddammit!

LINDA: Willy, please!

WILLY: Biff is a lazy bum!

LINDA: They're sleeping. Get something to eat. Go on down.

WILLY: Why did he come home? I would like to know what brought him home.
LINDA: I don't know. I think he's still lost, Willy. I think he's very lost.

WILLY: Biff Loman is lost. In the greatest country in the world a young man with such-personal attractiveness, gets lost. And such a hard worker. There's one thing about Biff he's not lazy.

LINDA: Never.

WILLY (with pity and resolve): I'll see him in the morning; I'll have a nice talk with him. I'll get him a job selling. He could be big in no time. My God! Remember how they used to follow him around in high school? When he smiled at one of them their faces lit up. When he walked down the street... (He loses himself in reminiscences.)

LINDA (trying to bring him out of it): Willy, dear, I got a new kind of American-type cheese today. It's whipped borrow)

WILLY: Why do you get American when I like Swiss?

LINDA: I just thought you'd like a change...

WILLY: I don't want a change! I want Swiss cheese. Why am I always being contradicted?

LINDA (with a covering laugh): I thought it would be a surprise.

WILLY: Why don't you open a window here, for God's sake?

LINDA (with infinite patience): They're all open, dear.

WILLY: The way they boxed us in here. Bricks and windows, windows and bricks.

LINDA: We should've bought the land next door.

WILLY: The street is lined with cars. There's not a breath of fresh air in the neighbourhood. The grass don't grow any more, you can't raise a carrot in the backyard. They should've had a law against apartment houses. Remember those two beautiful elm trees out there? When I and Biff hung the swing between them?

LINDA: Yeah, like being a million miles from the city.

WILLY: They should've arrested the builder for cutting those down. They massacred the neighbourhood. (Lost.) More and more I think of those days, Linda. This time of year it was lilac and wisteria. And then the peonies would come out, and the daffodils. What fragrance in this room!

LINDA: Well, after all, people had to move somewhere.

WILLY: No, there's more people now.

LINDA: I don't think there's more people. I think

WILLY: There's more people! That's what's ruining this country! Population is getting out of control. The competition is maddening! Smell the stink from that apartment house! And another one on the other side... How can they whip cheese?

(On Willy's last line, Biff and Happy raise themselves up in their beds, listening.)

LINDA: Go down, try it. And be quiet.

WILLY (turning to Linda, guiltily): You're not worried about me, are you, sweetheart?

BIFF: What's the matter?

HAPPY: Listen!

LINDA: You've got too much on the ball to worry about.

WILLY: You're my foundation and my support, Linda.

LINDA: Just try to relax, dear. You make mountains out of mole-hills.

WILLY: I won't fight with him anymore. If he wants to go back to Texas, let him go.

LINDA: He'll find his way.

WILLY: Sure. Certain men just don't get started till later in life. Like Thomas Edison; I think. Or B. F. Goodrich. One of them was deaf. (He starts for the bedroom doorway.) I'll put my money on Biff.

LINDA: And Willy-if it's a warm Sunday we'll drive in the country. And we'll open the windshield, and take lunch.

WILLY: No, the windshields don't open on the new cars.

LINDA: But you opened it today.

WILLY: Me? I didn't. (He stops.) Now isn't that peculiar! Isn't that remarkable... (He breaks off in amazement and fright as the flute is heard distantly.)

LINDA: What, darling?

WILLY: That is the most remarkable thing.

LINDA: What, dear?

WILLY: I was thinking of the Chevvy. (Slight pause.) Nineteen twenty-eight... when I had that red Chevvy... (Breaks off.) That's funny? I coulda sworn I was driving that Chevvy today.

LINDA: Well, that's nothing. Something must've reminded you.

WILLY: Remarkable. Ts. Remember those days? The way Biff used to simonize that car? The dealer refused to believe there were eighty thousand miles on it. (He shakes his head.) Heh! (To Linda.) Close your eyes, I'll be right up. (He walks out of the bedroom.)

HAPPY (to Biff): Jesus, maybe he smashed up the car again!

LINDA (calling after Willy): Be careful on the stairs, dear! The cheese is on the middle shelf. (She turns, goes over to the bed. takes his jacket, and goes out of the bedroom.)

Multiple Choice Questions

1. What major historical event significantly influenced Arthur Miller's understanding of society and shaped his dramatic works?

a) The First World War
b) The American Civil War
c) The Great Depression
d) The Cold War

2. Which of the following works established Arthur Miller's international reputation and won both the Pulitzer Prize and the Tony Award?

a) *The Crucible*
b) *All My Sons*
c) *A View from the Bridge*
d) *Death of a Salesman*

3. Who was the primary inspiration for the character of Willy Loman?

a) Arthur Miller's father
b) Arthur Miller's brother
c) Arthur Miller's uncle, Manny Newman
d) Arthur Miller's college professor

4. Which theme is most central to *Death of a Salesman*?

a) Colonialism and nationalism
b) The American Dream and its limitations
c) War and heroism
d) Scientific progress and technology

5. Why does Biff lose his admiration for Willy?

a) Willy loses his job
b) Willy refuses to support him financially
c) Biff discovers Willy's extramarital affair
d) Willy forces him to leave home

6. What does the transformation of Willy's neighbourhood symbolize in the play?

a) Economic prosperity and urban success
b) The growth of American democracy
c) The loss of personal freedom, security, and connection with nature
d) The rise of industrial employment opportunities

7. In the prescribed extract, what problem causes Willy to return home unexpectedly?

a) He loses an important business contract.
b) His car breaks down on the highway.
c) He becomes unable to concentrate while driving and nearly causes an accident.
d) He receives news of a family emergency.

Answers: 1. C; 2. D; 3. C; 4. B; 5. C; 6. C; 7. C.

Short Answer Questions

1. How does Arthur Miller redefine the concept of a tragic hero in *Death of a Salesman*?

Hint: Ordinary person as hero · Common man's struggle · Dignity and self-worth · Modern tragedy

2. Why does Willy Loman return home before completing his sales trip?

Hint: Mental exhaustion · Loss of concentration · Dangerous driving · Confusion and anxiety

3. What does Linda's treatment of Willy reveal about their relationship?

Hint: Love and devotion · Patience and understanding · Emotional support · Protective attitude

4. How does the play use the setting of Willy's house to reflect his feelings about modern society?

Hint: Urbanization · Apartment buildings · Loss of nature · Isolation and confinement · Nostalgia for the past

5. What conflicting views about Biff's character does Willy express in the extract?

Hint: Calls Biff lazy · Praises Biff's hard work · Parental expectations · Contradictory opinions · Willy's confusion and frustration

Essay Questions

1. Discuss Willy Loman as a representative of the American Dream. How does Arthur Miller use his character to critique modern society?

Hint: American Dream; success and failure; materialism; social expectations; illusion versus reality; Willy's tragic downfall.

2. Analyse the relationship between Willy and Linda. How does their conversation reveal Willy's psychological condition and Linda's role in the family?

Hint: Linda's patience and support; Willy's exhaustion; mental confusion; marital relationship; emotional dependence.

3. Examine the significance of setting and symbolism in the extract from *Death of a Salesman*.

Hint: Apartment buildings; loss of nature; Willy's memories; the house as a symbol; urbanization; isolation; changing American society.